



Thunderstorm 67/52 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 67/46 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Comey faces new federal charges

Case against ex-FBI chief centers on seashell photo some say is Trump threat

BY PERRY STEIN

Former FBI director James B. Comey has been indicted on allegations that a photo he posted on social media in 2025 constituted a dangerous threat to the president.

The indictment by a federal grand jury in North Carolina marks the second time the Justice Department has pursued a criminal prosecution against Comey and is the law enforcement agency's latest attempt to criminally charge one of President Donald Trump's longtime political foes.

The two charges stem from a photo that Comey posted online last year showing seashells on a beach that were arranged to write out "86 47."

Trump is the 47th president; "86" can mean banning or removing someone, but it can also be slang for killing a person.

The three-page indictment states that the seashells were "arranged in a pattern making out '86 47,' which a reasonable recipient who is familiar with the circumstances would interpret as a serious expression of an intent to do harm to the President of the United States."

Comey has suggested that he stumbled on the shell formation during a walk along the beach and did not arrange the shells himself. There is generally a high legal threshold to charge someone with threatening a person based on their language, and legal experts said it would be tough for the Justice Department to build a strong case with just the seashells.

SEE COMEY ON A9



JABIN BOTSFORD/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

King Charles III and Queen Camilla depart after the monarch's 28-minute address, during which he stayed scrupulously nonpartisan.

Charles urges checks on power in U.S. state visit

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM

King Charles III urged Americans and Britons to draw on their shared heritage to defend democratic values, including checks on executive power, as he exhorted U.S. lawmakers to address global problems collectively in an era of unusually sharp divisions.

In the course of his first state visit to the United States as monarch, Charles stayed scrupulously nonpartisan over the course of a 28-minute address to a joint meeting of Congress. But he promoted what he described as centuries of common interests, including in areas where President Donald Trump has sought a sharp break from U.S. precedent

in his drive to reshape American society and governance.

The United States and Britain should defend Ukraine, Charles said. An independent judiciary should deliver impartial justice. Diverse societies make countries strong. Societies must protect the natural world. And the U.S. and Europe should "ignore the clarion calls to become ever more inward-looking."

Charles is officially barred from engaging in politics and mentioned no political leader in his speech. The vision of the American role in the world that he outlined, however, stood in stark contrast to that of Trump, who has declared that migration weakens societies, used executive orders to bypass Congress, at-

tacked judges who rule against him, questioned the scientific consensus on climate change and declared his desire to wind down support for Ukraine's defense against Russia's invasion. The speech came on the same day that the Justice Department brought a new indictment against former FBI director James B. Comey, a longtime Trump target.

As the king spoke, the White House posted an image of Trump and Charles on X, calling it "TWO KINGS," with a crown emoji.

Drawing repeated bipartisan standing ovations from lawmakers who can rarely agree on even the most anodyne of issues, Charles used his position as a living symbol of a state — not an elected leader — to try to revital-

ize Anglo-American ties at a moment when many on both sides of the Atlantic have sought to turn their backs on each other.

"Ours is a partnership born out of dispute, but no less strong for it," the king told Congress, becoming just the second British royal to address the chambers after his mother, Queen Elizabeth II, spoke following the Persian Gulf War in 1991.

"Executive power is subject to checks and balances," Charles said, spurring bipartisan cheers and whistles from his audience at a time when the Republican-led Congress has greatly diminished its power largely by acquiescing to many of Trump's demands.

He declared his admiration for

SEE CHARLES ON A12

UAE's exit is a blow to OPEC

MOVE COMES AMID GLOBAL OIL SHOCK

Longtime clashes with Saudi Arabia over quotas

BY MOHAMAD EL CHAMAA

BEIRUT — The United Arab Emirates announced Tuesday that it would exit the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries, or OPEC, along with the wider group of partners known as OPEC+, effective May 1, in what could be a blow to control over prices by the group, long led in practice by Saudi Arabia.

"We thank OPEC and its member countries for decades of constructive cooperation," UAE Energy Minister Suhail Al Mazrouei said in a post to social media.

The move "reflects the UAE's long-term strategic and economic vision and evolving energy profile" read an official statement carried by a UAE state news agency, as disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz "continues to affect supply dynamics."

Reports that the UAE would leave have circulated for years, and the country has had disagreements with Saudi Arabia over oil production quotas.

President Donald Trump has long criticized OPEC for its role in determining global oil prices, calling it a "monopoly" during his first term in office. Addressing the World Economic Forum in 2025, Trump urged OPEC countries to lower oil prices.

While tensions between the UAE and OPEC have been building,

SEE OPEC ON A12

DHS's pivot to quieter tactics alarms MAGA base

BY DAVID NAKAMURA

A month into his tenure, Homeland Security Secretary Markwayne Mullin is facing mounting pressure from conservative groups that fear the Trump administration is going soft on its mass deportation agenda amid a public backlash over aggressive enforcement tactics.

Mullin has vowed to restore confidence in the Department of Homeland Security after the fatal shootings of two U.S. citizens in Minneapolis. In a recent cable news appearance, he expressed a desire to conduct enforcement in a "more quiet way."

Organizations such as the Mass Deportation Coalition, formed in March and led by the Heritage Foundation, interpret that approach as a potential betrayal of one of the president's core campaign promises. The coalition recently published a lengthy report concluding that the administration had deported 350,000 immigrants in the first year of President Donald Trump's second term, far fewer than the 650,000 deportations that Trump officials have cited.

The numbers "don't represent a victory in quantity," said the report, which offered 21 recommendations to vastly expand

SEE DHS ON A2

Gunman's alleged screed appears to use Bible to justify attack

BY DANIELLE PAQUETTE AND HANNAH NATANSON

Elizabeth Terlinden hoped it was a case of mistaken identity. Why would the guy she knew to be deeply Christian plot to kill the president? But as she read the accused gunman's alleged email screed, she recognized her former college classmate's voice.

"Yeah," she thought to herself, "that's Cole."

His tone — methodical, peppered with what she interpreted as gallows humor — was eerily familiar nine years after they'd lost touch. Terlinden had served as a co-leader of the Caltech Christian Fellowship with Cole Tomas Allen, the 31-year-old man charged with attempted assassi-

nation after bolting toward a glitzy press gala where President Donald Trump was set to speak Saturday.

Allen hadn't been afraid to take a stand as a 20-year-old — though in 2015, by Terlinden's recollection, he'd shown no appetite for violence. They'd clashed over whether to send their charity dollars to children

overseas or a local homeless shelter, and he'd upset her enough with his insistence on shipping toys that she walked out of the room in frustration. Yet back then, Terlinden respected him.

"The idea of doing what he felt to be his duty religiously and morally, regardless of personal consequences — yes, that does

seem to be in character," she said.

Now the onetime STEM major who'd applied his hyper focus to Bible study at the California Institute of Technology was twisting the faith he held dear, she said, "like an engineer optimizing a design problem in terms of targeting people."

In a note authorities said he'd

SEE ALLEN ON A7



JESSICA CHRISTIAN/SAN FRANCISCO CHRONICLE/AP

Musk takes the stand

Tesla CEO Elon Musk testified in federal court Tuesday in his lawsuit against ChatGPT-maker OpenAI, a battle that could upend the company that kicked off the AI arms race. **Story, A13**

GAO agrees to review DOJ's handling of Epstein release

BY THEODORIC MEYER

The Government Accountability Office plans to examine the Justice Department's handling of files related to Jeffrey Epstein after a bipartisan group of senators raised concerns that the department violated the law.

The Justice Department has released millions of pages of documents related to the late convicted sex offender since President Donald Trump signed a law in November requiring the department to make the records public with narrow restrictions.

But Democrats and some Republicans in Congress questioned whether the Justice Department released all the required files and have criticized officials for not redacting some victims' names and for redacting the names of some Epstein associates.

Sens. Jeff Merkley (D-Oregon),

Lisa Murkowski (R-Alaska), Ben Ray Lujan (D-New Mexico) and Dick Durbin (D-Illinois) last month asked the GAO — an independent agency that is part of the legislative branch — to look into how the department reviewed the files "and the resulting failure of the Department to follow the law, respond to Congress and protect victims."

Merkley said Tuesday that the GAO has agreed to do so.

"This independent investigation is an important step in holding this Administration accountable for siding with the rich and powerful to help cover up the abuse of our most vulnerable," Merkley said in a statement. "I'll keep fighting to use all the tools at my disposal to deliver justice for Epstein's victims and transparency for the American people."

SEE EPSTEIN ON A6

IN THE NEWS

ABC feud The FCC ordered a review of Disney's broadcast licenses following a new spate of criticism about Jimmy Kimmel. **A10**

Asylum case Justice Amy Coney Barrett, who has two adopted children from Haiti, will join her peers in considering the president's bid to end temporary protections for 353,000. **A3**

THE NATION **Federal officers** raided 22 Minneapolis businesses, many with ties to Somali community. **A5** **Texas** legislators are hostile to Camp Mystic reopening but may be powerless to stop it. **A8**

THE WORLD **The fates** of 1.3 million immigrants could be decided as the Supreme Court considers a pair of lawsuits filed on behalf of Haitians and Syrians fighting to keep temporary protected status. **A4**

THE ECONOMY **Sinking AI** stocks and another climb in oil prices helped pull Wall Street off its records. **A13** **Divisions** within the Federal Reserve over the president's push to deregulate Wall Street could present a major challenge for nominee Kevin Warsh. **A14**

STYLE **CBS elicited** the president's fury for quoting a "manifesto," touching on an unsettled debate. **B1**

SPORTS **Former NBA** player Damon Jones admitted in court he exploited his fame and access to profit from sports betting and rigged poker. **B7**

THE REGION **Maryland** is parting ways with the main contractor in the reconstruction of the Francis Scott Key Bridge over a cost dispute. **B13**

FOOD **Peak season** for farmers markets is just around the corner. How to make the most of it.

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